Brightleaf Studio

Employee Handbook

Version 3.2 · Effective 1 January 2026

Owned by the People team · people@brightleaf.example

Welcome to Brightleaf

Brightleaf Studio is a 64-person design and software agency with a studio in Austin, Texas and team members working remotely across the United States. We build websites, mobile apps and brand systems for clients in education, healthcare and retail.

This handbook explains how we work together: your time off, pay and benefits, expenses, equipment, and what to do when something goes wrong. It applies to all full-time and part-time employees. Contractors are covered by their own agreements and only the Code of Conduct section applies to them.

If this handbook and your employment contract disagree, your contract wins. The People team reviews the handbook every January and announces changes in the #announcements channel at least 30 days before they take effect.

How to use this handbook

- Each section starts with the rule, then the details and exceptions.
- Questions about a policy go to your manager first, then the People team.
- The current version always lives on the intranet under People › Handbook.

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1. Employment basics

Employment types

- **Full-time:** 40 hours a week, eligible for every benefit in this handbook.
- **Part-time:** 20 to 32 hours a week. Leave and the learning budget are pro-rated to your hours.
- **Contractors:** engaged through a statement of work, not covered by benefits.

Probation

Every new employee has a probation period of 90 days (three months). Your manager meets you at 30, 60 and 90 days to review how things are going. Probation can be extended once, by up to 60 days, if both of you agree more time is needed. You can take annual leave during probation, but remote work from outside the Austin area starts only after probation ends.

Notice periods

Situation	Notice required (either side)
During probation	1 week
After probation	4 weeks
Lead, Principal and Director roles	8 weeks

2. Working hours and remote work

Core hours

Core collaboration hours are 10:00 to 16:00 in your local time zone, Monday to Friday. Outside core hours you can arrange your day as you like, as long as your team knows when you are available. Meetings should not be booked before 9:00 or after 17:00 in the attendee's time zone.

Hybrid schedule

Employees who live within 50 miles of the Austin studio work hybrid: in the studio on Tuesdays and Thursdays and wherever they prefer the rest of the week. Fully remote work is available after probation with your manager's approval.

Working from another country

You may work from outside the United States for up to 30 days per calendar year. Tell the People team at least two weeks before you travel so they can check tax and immigration rules. Some client projects forbid access to their systems from abroad; your project lead will tell you if that applies.

Home office support

- A one-time home office stipend of $500 for a desk, chair or monitor.
- $40 a month toward your internet bill, paid with your salary.

3. Annual leave and holidays

Annual leave

Full-time employees get 24 days of paid annual leave each calendar year. Leave accrues at 2 days per month, and part-time employees receive a pro-rated amount based on their contracted hours. New starters accrue from their first day.

Request leave in the HR portal. For absences longer than three working days, submit your request at least two weeks in advance. Your manager responds within three working days.

Carrying leave over

You can carry up to 5 unused days into the next year. Carried-over days must be used by 31 March or they expire. Leave cannot be exchanged for pay, except when you leave Brightleaf.

Company holidays

The studio closes for 10 company holidays: New Year's Day, Martin Luther King Jr. Day, Memorial Day, Juneteenth, Independence Day, Labor Day, Thanksgiving Day, the day after Thanksgiving, Christmas Eve and Christmas Day. The studio also closes between 26 and 31 December; these days do not come out of your annual leave.

4. Sick leave

Every employee gets 10 days of paid sick leave per calendar year. Sick leave does not carry over and is not paid out when you leave.

Telling us you are sick

Message your manager before 10:00 on the first day you are off, then log the absence in the HR portal when you are back. If you are off for more than three consecutive working days, please send a doctor's note to the People team.

Mental health days

Mental health is health. You can use sick days for your mental health without giving a reason, and you do not need a doctor's note for these days unless the absence goes beyond three consecutive working days.

Longer illness

If you need more than 10 days in a year, talk to the People team. We offer short-term disability cover that pays 60% of your salary for up to 12 weeks after the first 10 days of absence.

5. Parental and family leave

Parental leave

Employees with at least six months of service are eligible for paid parental leave. The birthing parent receives 16 weeks at full pay. Non-birthing parents, including adoptive and foster parents, receive 8 weeks at full pay. Parental leave must be taken within 12 months of the birth or placement and can be split into up to two blocks.

Please tell your manager and the People team at least 8 weeks before your planned leave starts. When you return, you can work a reduced schedule of four days a week at full pay for your first four weeks back.

Bereavement leave

- 5 paid days for the death of an immediate family member (partner, child, parent, sibling).
- 2 paid days for extended family members and close friends.

Jury duty and caregiving

Jury duty is paid at full salary for up to 10 working days. Employees may also take up to 5 days of paid caregiver leave per year to look after a sick family member.

6. Pay and benefits

Payday

Salaries are paid monthly on the last working day of the month by direct deposit. Payslips are available in the HR portal two days before payday.

Salary reviews

Salaries are reviewed once a year in April, using the December performance review and market data. Promotions made in December take effect on 1 January.

Health insurance

Brightleaf pays 90% of the medical, dental and vision premium for employees and 70% for dependants. Cover starts on the first day of the month after your start date.

Retirement

We match 401(k) contributions up to 4% of your salary. The match vests immediately.

Other benefits

- $50 a month wellness allowance for a gym, classes or apps.
- Life insurance worth twice your annual salary, at no cost to you.
- Brightleaf does not currently offer stock options or equity.

7. Expenses and travel

Submit expenses in the Ledgerly app within 30 days of the purchase, with a photo of the receipt. Reimbursements are paid with the next salary run. Expenses submitted after 90 days will not be reimbursed.

Travel limits

Item	Limit
Hotel	$220 per night (up to $300 in New York or San Francisco)
Meals, domestic travel	$60 per day
Meals, international travel	$85 per day
Flights under 6 hours	Economy
Flights of 6 hours or more	Premium economy
Ground transport	Public transit or standard rideshare

Client entertainment

Client meals and events over $150 need your manager's approval before you book. Alcohol is reimbursed only at client events. Gifts to clients are limited to $75 per person per year.

What we do not reimburse

- Traffic or parking fines.
- Upgrades to flights or hotels beyond the limits above.
- Personal travel added to a business trip.

8. Learning and development

Every full-time employee has a learning budget of $1,500 per calendar year, plus 3 paid learning days to spend on courses, conferences or study. Part-time employees receive a pro-rated budget.

What the budget covers

- Online and in-person courses related to your role or your next role.
- Books, e-learning subscriptions and certification exam fees.
- Conference tickets. Conference travel comes from the team travel budget, not your learning budget.

Approvals

Anything over $300 needs your manager's approval before you buy. Unused budget does not carry over to the next year.

Repayment

If you leave Brightleaf within 12 months of completing a single course that cost more than $1,000, you will be asked to repay 50% of its cost. This does not apply if Brightleaf ends your employment.

9. Equipment and IT security

Your equipment

You will receive a MacBook Pro or ThinkPad laptop on your first day, and a replacement every three years. You can also order one external monitor, a keyboard and a mouse through the IT portal.

Security rules

- Two-factor authentication is mandatory on every work account.
- Store all passwords in the company password manager.
- Never keep client data on personal devices or personal cloud storage.
- Lock your screen whenever you leave your laptop.

Lost or stolen devices

Report a lost or stolen laptop or phone to it@brightleaf.example within 24 hours, even outside working hours. IT will wipe the device remotely. You will not be charged for a lost device unless it was lost through repeated negligence.

Personal use

Reasonable personal use of your laptop is fine, such as personal email or browsing. Do not install pirated software, games with anti-cheat drivers, or cryptocurrency mining tools.

10. Performance and growth

Reviews

Performance reviews take place twice a year, in June and December. Each review includes a self-assessment, feedback from two peers you choose, and a conversation with your manager. The December review informs promotions and the April salary review.

One-to-ones

You meet your manager one-to-one every two weeks. These meetings are yours: bring blockers, ideas and career questions.

Promotions

Promotions are decided once a year in December by a panel of studio leads, based on our published career framework. You can ask your manager to put you forward.

Performance improvement plans

If performance falls below expectations, your manager will first raise it in your one-to-ones. If things do not improve, we use a written performance improvement plan lasting 60 days, with clear goals and weekly check-ins.

11. Code of conduct and reporting concerns

We expect everyone to treat colleagues, clients and partners with respect. Harassment, discrimination and bullying are not tolerated, whether in the studio, online, at client sites or at company events.

How to report a concern

- Talk to your manager or any studio lead.
- Email the People team at people@brightleaf.example.
- Use the anonymous SpeakUp form on the intranet. Reports go to an external provider, not to Brightleaf staff.

The People team starts an investigation within 5 working days of a report and keeps the person who raised it informed. Retaliation against anyone who raises a concern in good faith is itself a serious breach of this code.

Gifts and conflicts of interest

Declare any gift from a client or supplier worth more than $75 to the People team. Tell your manager about any side project or outside job that could compete with Brightleaf or its clients.

12. Leaving Brightleaf

To resign, email your manager and the People team with your intended last day, giving the notice period that applies to you (see Employment basics).

Before your last day

- Hand over your projects using the handover template on the intranet.
- Return your laptop and other equipment within 5 working days of your last day. IT sends a prepaid box to remote employees.
- Book an optional exit interview with the People team.

Final pay

Your final salary includes payment for any unused annual leave, including carried-over days. Unused sick leave and learning budget are not paid out.

References

Brightleaf references confirm only your job title and dates of employment. Managers may not give personal references on company letterhead.

13. Who to contact

Topic	Contact
Leave, benefits, payroll, policies	People team · people@brightleaf.example
Laptops, accounts, lost devices	IT · it@brightleaf.example
Expenses and reimbursements	Finance · finance@brightleaf.example
Anonymous concerns	SpeakUp form on the intranet
Studio access and facilities	Studio manager · studio@brightleaf.example

The People team is available Monday to Friday, 9:00 to 17:00 Central Time, and aims to reply within one working day.